

Bitis gabonica

Gaboon viper



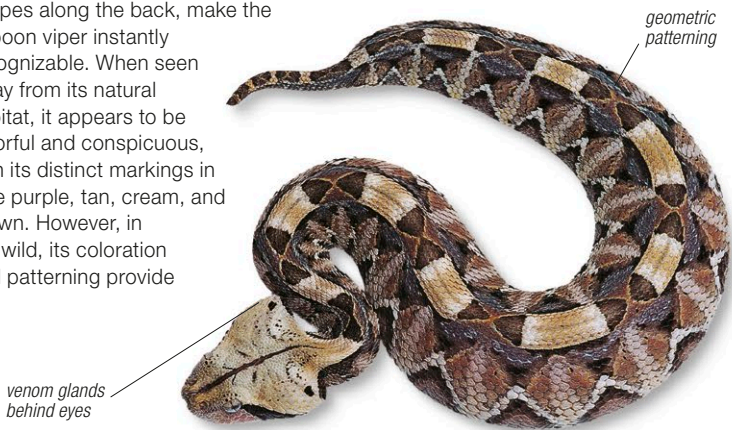
Length 4 ft (1.2 m),
max 6½ ft (2 m)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location W. and C. Africa



The immense, thickset body, massive, triangular head with small eyes, and patterning of interlocking, geometric shapes along the back, make the gaboon viper instantly recognizable. When seen away from its natural habitat, it appears to be colorful and conspicuous, with its distinct markings in pale purple, tan, cream, and brown. However, in the wild, its coloration and patterning provide

excellent camouflage, making it extremely difficult to detect. A sluggish, usually placid snake, it generally lies motionless on the forest floor, moving only when prey—namely rodents and larger mammals, birds, and frogs—comes within striking range. Large, heavy-bodied individuals normally crawl in a straight line, like a caterpillar. When disturbed, this viper gives a loud, low hiss and may bite, but only as a last resort; the bite is often fatal to humans if not treated at once. Males combat during the breeding season, and females give birth to 16–60 young every 2–3 years.



Echis pyramidum

Northeast African saw-scaled viper



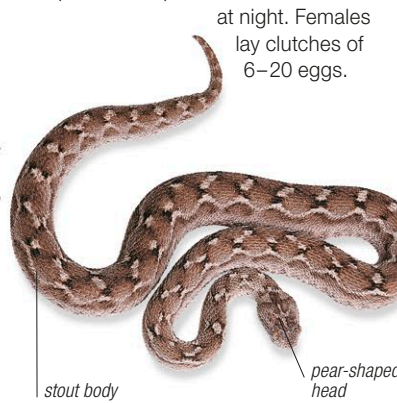
Length 12–23½ in
(30–60 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location N. and N.E. Africa



Despite its small size, this quick-moving snake is highly dangerous, with venom potent enough to kill humans. It belongs to a small genus of vipers (known as saw-scaled or carpet vipers) that have strongly keeled scales that produce a loud rasping sound when they are

rubbed together. When threatened, saw-scaled vipers use this sound as a warning signal, in much the same way as rattlesnakes (see p.404) use their tails. Like its relatives, the northeast African saw-scaled viper hunts small mammals, amphibians, reptiles, and invertebrates at night. Females lay clutches of 6–20 eggs.



Vipera ammodytes

Nose-horned viper



Length 26–35 in
(65–90 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location S.E. Europe,
W. Asia



The light brown, reddish brown, or gray nose-horned viper is Europe's most dangerous snake, although its bite is rarely fatal if treated. It has a short, fleshy horn on its snout, the function of which is as yet



unknown. It is usually slow-moving, unless provoked, and often coils quietly among rocks on hillsides. Mainly diurnal, it may become nocturnal in midsummer in certain parts of its range.



Cerastes cerastes

Desert horned viper



Length 12–23½ in
(30–60 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location N. Africa



Also known as the Sahara horned viper, this short, squat snake usually has a thornlike horn over each eye. The strongly keeled scales on its body help the snake shuffle down into the sand, where it remains hidden and

protected from the heat. Active at night, it lies in ambush for rodents, lizards, and birds, sometimes partially buried, then launches a rapid strike. When threatened, it forms a coil, rubbing together the scales on its flanks to create a rasping sound.

dusty color provides camouflage



Daboia russelli

Russell's viper



Length 3¼ ft (1 m),
max 5 ft (1.5 m)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

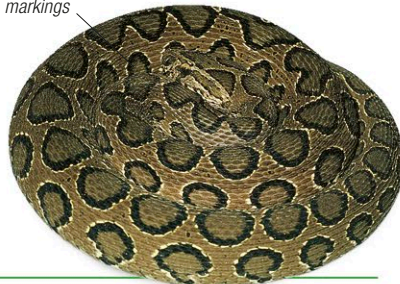
Location S. and S.E. Asia



Although this is a sluggish animal that usually remains coiled and well hidden during the day, Russell's viper is one of the most dangerous snakes to humans in southern Asia. It is distinguished by its light brown body with 3 rows of oval,

dark-edged brown blotches down its back. A sit-and-wait predator, it relies on its camouflage to escape detection by unwary prey, then strikes. In defense, it forms a tight coil, hisses, and strikes hard, often lifting its body off the ground in the process.

stout body with distinctive markings



Vipera berus

Common adder



Length 26–35 in
(65–90 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Semiterrestrial
Status Least concern

Location Europe, C. to
E. Asia



The common adder—or common viper—is the only venomous snake in northwest Europe, and is the most widely distributed snake in the viper family. It lives in a wide range of habitats, including rocky slopes 9,900 ft (3,000 m) high in the European Alps, and open tundra north of the Arctic Circle. Its color varies from gray, brown, or rust to completely black, but most individuals have a distinctive, zigzag line running down their back. Common adders may occasionally reach as much as 35 in (90 cm) long. They feed primarily on small rodents and lizards, either ambushing or actively pursuing them, but they also spend much of their time basking in the sun. In the north of their range, where winters are colder—for example, in Scandinavia—they hibernate for up to 8 months each year. In spring, the snakes emerge to

mate, with males engaging in protracted combat for the chance to pair up with females. Females breed only about once every 2 or 3 years, producing litters of up to 20 young that may have been fathered by several different males. Adders are only mildly venomous. In humans, their bite can cause swelling and pain, but is rarely fatal.

flat head

